willingness to allow Soviet hegemony in East Berlin to preserve the security of West Berlin. In October Khrushchev withdrew the ultimatum on the Peace Treaty, though he remained impatient to make progress on the broader issue and was frustrated he had yet to receive any reply from Washington to his recent proposals.

Both men, however, faced other challenges and had other agendas. The twenty-second congress of the Soviet communist party provided the latest battleground between Khrushchev and Mao for the hearts and minds of the international communist movement. Khrushchev faced continuing Chinese criticism for seeking a *modus vivendi* with Kennedy (albeit on terms unacceptable to Kennedy). In the same speech on 17 October 1961 that he dropped the Berlin ultimatum, Khrushchev announced that Moscow would soon test a fifty megaton thermonuclear device.

In this context, Washington chose to effectively call Khrushchev's bluff about his ICBMs. On 21 October 1961 the Deputy Secretary of Defense, Roswell Gilpatric, delivered a speech making clear that, in the event of a Soviet attack, US retaliation would be, 'at least as extensive as what the Soviets can deliver by striking first.'[39] Gilpatric signalled that Washington now understood the reality of US superiority. It was a means by which Kennedy could demonstrate strength in his handling of the Berlin problem.

In 1961 Kennedy and Khrushchev were under pressure from their military establishments to resume nuclear testing, though in Vienna Khrushchev had promised that Moscow would only do so if Washington ended the moratorium. Khrushchev reneged and Soviet tests resumed in September. 'Fucked again,' was Kennedy's embittered private reaction.[40] His public response was the resumption of US nuclear testing.

On 30 October 1961 the Soviets exploded the largest thermonuclear device ever seen. The RDS-220 Tsar Bomba was dropped from a specially modified Tupolev-95 bomber over Novaya Zemlya in the Barents Sea.[41] The explosive yield was some fifty-eight megatons (significantly below its potential explosive power of one hundred megatons).

Aleksandr Fursenko and Timothy Naftali recount that the GRU told Khrushchev that it was the announcement of the impending tests that deterred Washington from launching a pre-emptive nuclear attack on the